

Filming a moment instead of watching it happen

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

You're holding the phone up because you're scared of losing this. Keeping it down doesn't cost you the memory, it protects it, and what a recording never quite gives back is being there while it happened.

THE GOAL

What you want is to feel like you were really there, not just to own proof you attended. Put the phone down before it starts and give the moment your eyes.

CHECKLIST

You're standing there with your phone already up, right as the thing you wanted to catch is about to start, and you haven't decided yet whether to lower it.

- ☐ Lower the phone to your side, or slide it into your pocket, before anything starts.
- ☐ Pick one thing to watch, like their face or their hands, and keep your eyes on it instead of a screen.
- ☐ If your hand drifts back toward the phone, clasp it with your other hand or fold your arms instead.
- ☐ If someone else is already assigned to shoot this, like a hired photographer, count on that and leave your own phone down.
- ☐ If you still want it recorded, prop the phone against something solid, like a rail or your knee, not your eye.
- ☐ Glance once to confirm it's recording, a moving timer or a red dot, before you look away from the screen for good.
- ☐ If it's a photo, frame in tight on their hands or the rings, not the wide shot.
- ☐ Take the photo or clip you wanted, then put the phone away and don't pick it up again until the moment is over.
- ☐ If you reach for it again anyway, occupy your hands with something else, like a program or a drink, until it's over.
- ☐ Before you raise anything, check you're not standing where you'd block the view behind you or the photographer's shot.
- ☐ Once the moment ends, leave the phone alone and look at the person next to you instead of your screen.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Stopping to take a photo isn't free. It measurably lowers how much you enjoy something you're already enjoying.
- 2** Most people guess a photo adds to their enjoyment, or changes nothing. Measured against what happened, most guessed wrong.
- 3** Pick a detail to photograph, not the whole scene. Unzoomed parts stay just as clear in memory instead of fading.

What it costs you right now

DON'T

Stopping to take a photo isn't free. It measurably lowers how much you enjoy something you're already enjoying.

Pausing to snap photos of an absorbing video left people enjoying it noticeably less than simply watching did. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Most people guess a photo adds to their enjoyment, or changes nothing. Measured against what happened, most guessed wrong.

Asked in advance, most people guessed photographing something great would help or do nothing to their enjoyment. [Source 1](#)

What filming protects, and what it doesn't

KNOW

Photographing something and looking at it are not the same for memory. People came away with fewer details about whatever they'd photographed than whatever they'd only looked at.

People on a museum tour remembered fewer details about objects they'd photographed than ones they had simply looked at. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Don't count on taking several photos, or changing the angle, to make up for not fully watching. People who took multiple photos still remembered less than people who only watched.

Taking several photos of a painting still left people remembering fewer details than taking none did. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

A quick photo feels like the safe, low-cost option. People who took just a quick photo remembered it worse than people who took several.

People told to take just a quick photo of a painting later remembered it worse than people told to take several photos of it. [Source 3](#)

DO

Pick a detail to photograph, not the whole scene. Unzoomed parts stay just as clear in memory instead of fading.

Zooming in on a part of an object while photographing it kept people's memory of the whole object intact, other parts included. [Source 2](#)

Why this one moment, not the whole day

KNOW

Taking photos helps with a duller stretch, but gets in the way once a moment grips you instead.

Photographing gives you something to do, which helps in dull stretches but competes with attention a gripping moment already holds. [Source 4](#)

WATCH

Once you're filming, your attention shifts toward composing the shot instead of the moment. Notice that pull and look up again, because the moment is still happening while you aim the camera at it.

Taking photos pulls your attention toward whatever would make a good picture, not toward the moment itself. [Source 4](#)

Sources

1. <https://source.washu.edu/2019/01/study-live-in-the-moment-dont-selfie-or-snap-it/>
2. <https://fairfield.elsevierpure.com/en/publications/point-and-shoot-memories-the-influence-of-taking-photos-on-memory/>
3. <https://www.bps.org.uk/research-digest/our-memory-worse-things-weve-photographed-even-when-weve-taken-multiple-photos>
4. <https://europepmc.org/article/MED/27267324>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Weddings and celebrations at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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